



Painted c. 581–618, this fresco is from China's Dunhuang caves, in a strategic Silk Road oasis. The caves contain some of the finest examples of Buddhist art.

IN 581, YANG JIAN, A GENERAL OF THE ZHOU RULERS of northern China, rebelled and took the throne for himself as the emperor **Wendi** (r. 581–604). In 589, he invaded southern China. His forces rapidly overcame those of the last Chen emperor, **Hou Zhu**. Wendi was now the country's sole ruler and the first emperor of the **Sui dynasty**; after three centuries of division, **China** was finally **united**. Wendi disarmed private armies and established agricultural colonies along China's frontiers to strengthen central control in remote areas. He implemented a **major land reform** that increased the number of households liable to the land tax from 4 million in 589, to almost 9 million in 606. Wendi also extended the country's canal system to form a "**Grand Canal**"

“NOT ANGLES, BUT ANGELS.”

Pope Gregory I, on seeing Anglo-Saxon slaves at a market in Rome

that allowed vessels to travel 1,240 miles (2,000 km) from Hangzhou in the southeast to the northeastern provinces around Beijing, via Luoyang in eastern central China. Austere, strict, and occasionally violent, Wendi seemed to have set the Sui dynasty on firm foundations; in the end, it lasted only 14 years after his death, when it was replaced by the Tang.

In 582, **Emperor Maurice** succeeded **Tiberius II** (r. 578–82) as the Byzantine emperor. He had been commander of the palace

guard and then of the war against the Persians from 578. Tiberius's overspending and ineffective campaigns against the Persians, Lombards, and Avars had **emptied the imperial treasury**, leaving Maurice facing an immediate financial crisis. His subsequent economizing led to **mutinies** by the eastern army in 588 and by that of the Balkans in 593. Maurice made his father Paul head of the Senate and his brother-in-law **Philippicus** head of the palace guard; such nepotism further increased his unpopularity.

In 584, Maurice **renewed the war with Persia**, appointing Philippicus to oversee it. The new commander attacked Arzanene, but his campaign was disrupted by the **defection of the Ghassanid Arabs**—former allies alienated by the arrest of their king, al-Mundhir. The mutiny of the eastern troops in 588 caused Byzantine efforts to stall further, and in 589 they lost the city of **Martyropolis** (in present-day Turkey) to the Persians. The Byzantines were saved by the outbreak of a civil war in Persia; the involvement of a Byzantine army in the restoration of one Persian claimant, **Chosroes II**, led to the recovery of Martyropolis and Dara in 592.

In the Balkans, the **Slavs**—a non-Germanic people referred to as “Sclaveni” in contemporary sources—seem to have arrived north of the Danube in the early to mid-6th century. When the Avars moved into the region in c. 559 the Slavs were pushed farther south. By the end of the 6th century, Slavic groups had settled as far south as northern Greece, the Dalmatian coast of the Adriatic, and Macedonia, as well as in those areas of Bulgaria, Bohemia, Moravia, Serbia, and Croatia where the great Slav kingdoms of the Middle Ages would later arise.

In 596, **Pope Gregory I** sent a mission to Britain to revive Christianity, following the invasions by **pagan Anglo-Saxons** in the 5th and early 6th centuries. The missionaries set out under **Augustine**, a former prior of a monastery in Rome, and arrived in Kent the following year. Their reception was reasonably warm as Bertha, the wife of the **Kentish king Aethelberht**, was already Christian. After Aethelberht was baptized a Christian, Augustine was able to establish a church in Canterbury. **King Saebert of Essex** and **King Sigebert of East Anglia**—both

dependent on Kent—also converted, but the infant English Church would suffer a series of setbacks before the last Anglo-Saxon kingdoms became Christian in the late 7th century.



Sui dynasty figurine
This figure depicting a trader on a camel emphasizes China's continuing concern with commerce along the Silk Road through Central Asia.



POPE GREGORY I (590–604)

From 572 to 574 Gregory I was prefect of Rome, and only became a monk on his father's death. A man of great ability and energy, he was involved in resistance to the Lombards in Italy in the early part of his papacy, but he maintained good relations with the Merovingians in Francia and the Visigothic rulers of Spain. Relations with the Byzantine emperor Maurice broke down over the use of the title “ecumenical patriarch” by the Bishop of Constantinople, which Gregory viewed as a challenge to his authority.

589 Visigothic king Recared announces conversion of the country to Catholicism at Council of Toledo

589 The western Turks based in Dzungaria, control the Silk Road

589 Yang Jian captures the Sui capital, reuniting China

589 Byzantines lose city of Martyropolis to the Persians (retaken in 592)

589 Slavs begin to move into the Balkans

591 Byzantines II restore Chosroes II to the Persian throne

592 Civil war breaks out in China between the pro-Buddhist Soga and anti-Buddhist Mononobe clans

595 Indian mathematicians use the decimal system

597 St. Augustine begins mission to convert England to Christianity

598 Byzantines agree treaty with the Lombards, conceding northern Italy to them